PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

The United States Colored Troops — A House Divided

What the Numbers Prove

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about The United States Colored Troops — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Statistics are evidence. Read the figures on Black service carefully, then use them to build an argument

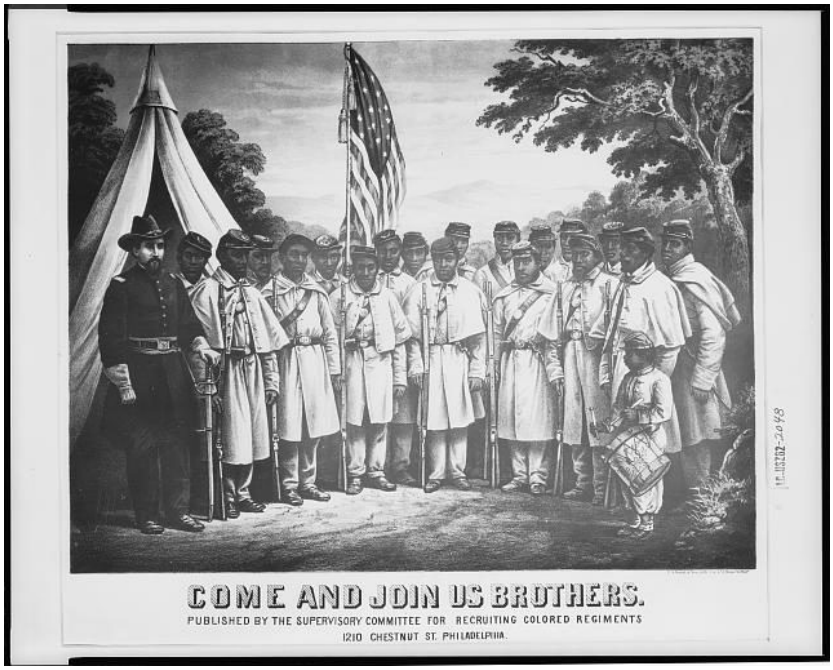
THE SOURCES

DATA SET · THE U.S. COLORED TROOPS, 1863–1865 — Black service in the Union war effort

Measure	*Figure*
Black men in the USCT (army)	*~180,000*
Share of the whole Union army	*~10%*
USCT regiments raised	*~175*
Black men in the Union Navy	*~19,000*
USCT dead (most from disease)	*~40,000*
Medals of Honor (soldiers + sailors)	*23*
Monthly pay, Black soldier (until 1864)	*$10 – clothing fee*
Monthly pay, white soldier	*$13.*

Standard historical estimates, rounded. Public domain data.

THE IMAGE · 1863 — "Come and Join Us Brothers"



"Come and Join Us Brothers" — recruiting broadside for the U.S. Colored Troops, 1863, public domain (Library of Congress).

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · READ THE DATA

Using the table: how many Black men served in the army and navy combined? About what share of the Union army was Black? Write both figures.

_____

_____

_____

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · READ THE INEQUALITY

For most of the war, a Black soldier earned $10 (minus a clothing fee) while a white soldier earned $13. What did the men of the 54th Massachusetts do about it?

- ☐ A. they accepted the lower pay without complaint
- ☐ B. they left the army
- ☐ C. they refused all pay for over a year until Congress granted equal pay
- ☐ D. they were never paid at all

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · ADDED RISK

Black soldiers faced a danger white soldiers did not if they were captured. Explain what that danger was, and name the 1864 event where it happened.

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · MAKE THE ARGUMENT

Frederick Douglass argued that putting on the uniform earned Black men “the right to citizenship.” Using at least two numbers from the data set, write a short argument (3–4 sentences) explaining how the service of the USCT supported the case for the 13th, 14th, and 15th Amendments.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The United States Colored Troops — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Combined: about ___. Share of the army: about ___%."

QUESTION 2: **Correct — C. they refused all pay for over a year until Congress granted equal pay**

Right. The 54th refused to accept ANY pay rather than accept unequal pay — a protest that lasted over a year, until Congress granted equal pay in 1864. They risked their lives for free to make the point.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "If captured, Black soldiers risked…. This happened at…"

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "With about ___ men serving — roughly ___% of the army — Black soldiers proved…"